

offering IM functionality. You need not have the Google Talk application installed to use this feature.

When you log into the Gmail mailbox, your previous chat status is restored. The status in the IM client can be changed under the “Set Status Here” link. You can sign out of Chat or sign in and be Available. You can set your status to Busy, in which case others will still be able to send messages, but there will be a gentle reminder that they “may be interrupting.” Custom messages allow you to add a personal touch. Once logged into the IM client, you can receive and send messages—from and to users of either Google Talk or Gmail.

To initiate an IM session, just double-click on any of the contacts listed under the chat box that are online (online contacts have a green circle next to their IDs). A small window pops up near the bottom left of the screen, and you can type in and receive messages as you would when using any IM client. If desired, the pop-out can be put into a separate window by clicking the “pop-out” link.

If the contact is offline, the messages are sent to his Inbox.

10.2.9 Reading and Writing E-mails

Reading an e-mail is the same as is in all e-mail service providers. Gmail offers the ability to prevent images from being automatically loaded. The links “Display Images below” and “Always display images from source” can be used to configure these criteria for each e-mail source. Clicking on the “More Options” link beside the message title will reveal other options like “Add sender to Contact List”. The “Report Phishing” link can be used to flag suspicious e-mails: “Show Original Link” will show the e-mail headers that will reveal information about the actual servers from where the e-mail originated.

Replying to e-mails can be done by using the quick reply box below each e-mail you read. To compose a new e-mail, use the “Compose e-mail” link. This opens the e-mail composer, which comes packed with a rich text editor and spell checking capabilities.